3.3 The War of 1812

Americans value their independence. That's what the American Revolution had been about, after all. Turns out, many Americans would be willing to fight for it a second time.

MAIN IDEA The War of 1812 unified the people of the United States and set the stage for expansion and economic prosperity.

A NATION AT ODDS

In June 1812, the War Hawks got their way. Congress declared war against Britain—again. However, despite the widespread belief that the British and Native Americans were working together, Americans had mixed feelings about the **War of 1812**. As you know, the war with Britain was especially unpopular with New England farmers and merchants for economic reasons.



Francis Scott Key watched the American flag continue to fly above Fort McHenry, shown here, through bombardment by British warships.

Politicians also wondered how President James Madison planned to pay for the war. The National Bank's charter had expired, leaving only the less stable state banks to provide war loans. Also, you may remember that the United States had ended trade with Britain and France while those two countries were at war. The government had lost a great deal of income from tariffs as a result.

THROUGH THE PERILOUS FIGHT

At first, busy fighting Napoleon, Britain all but ignored the war with the United States. However, Britain had to act when American forces attacked its fort near Detroit, Michigan. The British repelled the attack and even forced the U.S. militia to surrender Detroit. Things were beginning badly for the Americans.

In September 1813, American troops won their first victory when **Oliver Hazard Perry** and his fleet of ships defeated British troops on Lake Erie. Soon after, William Henry Harrison's forces retook Detroit and defeated British forces at the Battle of the Thames (tehmz). Shawnee chief Tecumseh died on that battlefield fighting for the British.

By the summer of 1814, Britain's war against Napoleon in Europe was drawing to a close, so the country sent more troops to North America. British forces captured Washington, D.C., and burned down the Capitol and White House. Less than a month later, the British also attacked **Fort McHenry** and Baltimore, Maryland, but failed to take the city. The American flag flying amid the battle's flaming rockets and bombs inspired **Francis Scott Key** to memorialize the scene in his poem "The Star-Spangled Banner." The poem was later set to music and became the national anthem of the United States. (You can read more about Key's famous lyrics and our flag earlier in this text in the American Story, "Our American Identity.")

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The White House Washington, D.C.

This painting by Tom Freeman, called *Burning of the White House, 1814*, shows the structure in flames after British soldiers torched it during the War of 1812. Before their arrival, Madison's wife, Dolley, had a full-length portrait of George Washington removed and taken from the building for safekeeping.

CRITICAL VIEWING What emotions is the painting probably meant to inspire?

By the end of 1814, neither Britain nor the United States saw much hope for victory. Delegates from both countries met in Ghent, a city in present-day Belgium, where they signed the Treaty of Ghent and formally ended the war. News of the treaty did not come soon enough to stop one last British naval and ground attack on New Orleans, however. **Andrew Jackson**, a military leader from Tennessee, and his troops countered the attack and killed, captured, or wounded more than 2,000 British soldiers. Jackson lost only 13 soldiers.

The terms of the treaty restored things to the way they were before the war. All territory captured during the war was returned to its original owner, and all prisoners of war were freed.

Although the treaty did not declare a winner, many Americans felt they'd scored a diplomatic victory. The war confirmed U.S. sovereignty and boosted Americans' self-confidence and patriotism. It also encouraged yet more expansion and a new economic prosperity.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why were Americans divided over fighting the War of 1812?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What happened because news of the Treaty of Ghent didn't arrive immediately?
3. **FORM AND SUPPORT OPINIONS** Do you think Americans were justified in their belief that they had won the war? Explain why or why not.

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